The Challenges of Remote Management

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Topics

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Remote Management Scenarios

Types of team

- Full time teleworkers plus office-based employees
- Workers who work some time in the office, some time at home
- Entirely home-based team
- Home-based manager

Example – my experience

- 1 month at home with a broken ankle.
- 6 months working 50% from home in Barcelona
- 2 years as Team Lead working from home
- 7 years as home-based Manager in Bristol managing office and home-based workers in Boston, Chicago, Barcelona.

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Statistics

Companies offering some form of teleworking:

2006 – 14%

2011 – 59%

Source: CBI/Harvey Nash (2011)

Laws

- Since April 2003, parents with children under six or disabled have right to request telework.
- April 2009…extended to children < 17 and to carers of adults.

Source : Work and Families Act 2006 amendment for Flexible Working Regulations 2009.

http://www.legislation.gov.uk/uksi/2009/595/regulation/2/made

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Considerations – Hardware

Hardware needs

- PC or laptop
- Printer
- Scanner/fax (esp. if employee needs to send signed forms)

Considerations

- Who is responsible for the hardware?
- Purchasing direct vs. shipped with pre-installed company software?
- Future software updates? Can existing office-based processes be extended to teleworkers?
- Technical assistance and repair?

Tip: Keep a spare laptop in the office ready to ship to teleworkers.

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Considerations – Home Utilities and Consumables

As a company / manager you need a policy for the following:

- Phone
- Internet
- Stationary and printer consumables

DTI Recommendation:

- Provide a second line to clearly differentiate between home and office life

Heating and lighting?

- Not usually reimbursed, but if so the (UK) company can deduct tax

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Considerations – Ergonomics and Safety

"Telework Guidance" DTI/Pub 6856/10k/08/03/NP. URN 03/1201

Employer must assess home workplace…for electrical safety and ergonomic use of equipment.

EC Directive 90/270/EEC – Visual Display Equipment

- Display screen and keyboard
- Work surface and chair
- Space and lighting
- Noise and heat

Tip: Create a checklist for each employee to complete and sign.

Tip: Encourage employees to consider fire safety too.

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Considerations – Communications

Communication is key!

Managers should make communication as easy as possible.

- Phone
- Email
- Instant messaging
- Desktop sharing

➢ Define a sick leave protocol.

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Considerations – Meetings

Informal, but scheduled 1x1 meetings

- Virtual coffee chats
- Keep it personal

Scheduled team meetings

- Go out of your way to get remote employees involved

Tip: Proceed with meetings even when nothing new to talk about

Team summits

- Get the team together to discuss infrastructure and general issues
- Even *virtual* summits work well!

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Considerations – Access to Company Resources

Company resources could include the following:

- Intranet
- HR tools for expenses, vacations, sick leave, time recording
- Project documentation (SharePoint, network folders)
- Customer support portals, such as Siebel
- Source control

  - You really just need a good internet and VPN connection.

- Access to software products that need documenting

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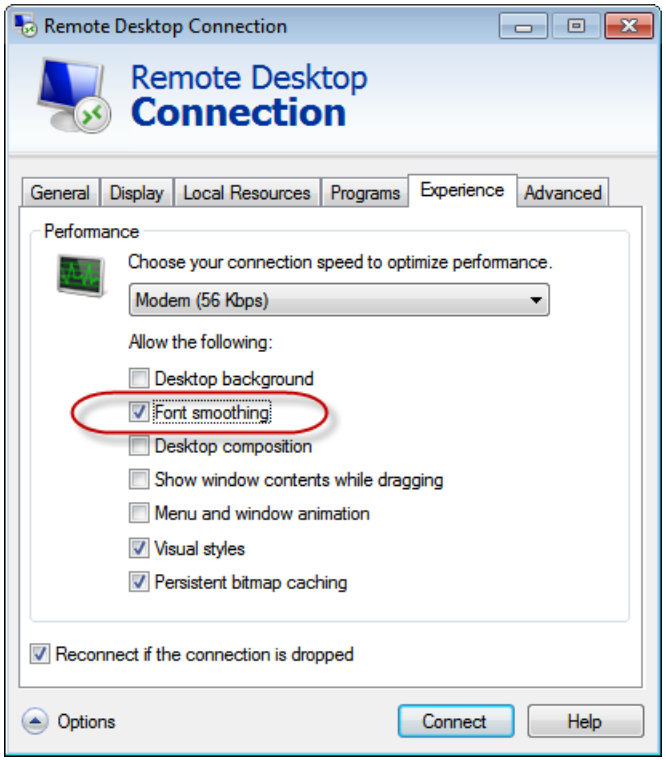
Considerations – Software Tips 1

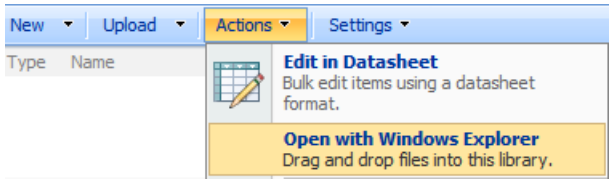
Remote Desktop

- Optimize for screenshots



SharePoint

- Easier to move items around in Explorer view



(Avoid popups by adding SharePoint as a local intranet site in browser settings.)

Downloading files locally

Advise team members to routinely download internal project documentation and other files locally.

- Using MS DOS xcopy feature:

xcopy "\\intranet.company.com\Projects\Shared Documents\" /D:01-01-2012 /e /f /y /z/

  - Edit path in yellow
  - Enter date of the last retrieval to get all files modified since this date.

- …or using a file synchronization tool:

Tip: Beyond Compare does a great job

More software-related tips

- Configure VPN server to allow access to local network.
- Use a desktop search engine to locate info as email usage will increase

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Considerations – Employee Performance

Employee performance

- Performance often improves after the initial weeks.
- Better if manager has telework experience.
- Managers need to trust employees and set expectations that are concrete and measurable.

Keeping to the right path

- Good idea to monitor performance in different ways:
  - Timesheets for the first few months
  - Weekly progress reports
  - Bi-annual reviews against objectives set earlier in year

Give praise whenever you can!

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Considerations – Security 1

PC/Laptop data

- Operating system and antivirus updates
- Enforce security via group policy

  Tip: Use group policy to restrict burning to CD/DVD.
- Encrypt computer (BitLocker, TrueCrypt…)

  TPM-module computers offer single logon

  Tip: Disable sleep mode and just use hibernation.
- Need a clear policy regarding use of a work computer for private use
- Legal obligations regarding monitoring (EC Directive 90/270/EEC)
- Admin rights?

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Considerations – Security 2

Peripherals

- Data copied elsewhere in local network is as safe as the weakest link.

  Tip: Encrypt all USB storage devices.

Printouts

- Establish policy for storage and destruction of printouts

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Considerations – Backup Policy

Local backup

Quick and painless. Safeguards against…

- Computer failure
- Corrupt or inadvertently edited/deleted files

Tip: Daily backup to encrypted NAS in other room.

Remote backup to office / cloud

Requires more time/processing. Safeguards against …

- House fire
- Burglary
- Employee on vacation/sick

Tip: Weekly backup. Monthly “test” of backed up data by manager.

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Considerations – International Issues

Be aware of …

- Time difference
- Customs
- Holidays
- Communication issues. Annunciate. Beware of tricky expressions.

  Tip: Encourage same writing style in team emails as used in manuals for an international audience

More tips

- Clarify meeting “dead zones”
- Watch out for clock changes on different days in Spring and Autumn.
- Calendar showing who’s around

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Considerations – Hiring and Firing/Redundancies

Hiring

- Pay as much attention to attitude and mind-set as technical knowledge and experience.
- Period of office-based work before remote work
- Clarify that teleworking is temporary and can be cancelled any time
- Before starting telework there needs to be a process for ending it

Letting staff go

- No nice way to do this remotely. If possible, arrange a visit to the employee's home or have him/her attend a nearby office.
- Make sure you have a backup of the employee's data.
- If possible, arrange for a nearby colleague to check up.

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Remote management is challenging, but can also be very rewarding!

Addendum - Details of Right to Flexible Working (April 2003)

The procedure

In summary, the procedure is as follows:

It is up to the employee to make a considered application in writing. They are only able to make one application a year under the right, and accepted applications will mean a **permanent** change to the employee's own terms and conditions of employment unless otherwise agreed between both parties. It is important therefore that, before making an application, the employee gives careful consideration to which working pattern will help them best care for their child; any financial implications it might have on them in cases where the desired working pattern will involve a drop in salary; and any effects it will have on their employer's business and how these might be accommodated.

Within **28 days** of receiving the request, the employer must arrange to meet with the employee. This provides the employer and the employee with the opportunity to explore the proposed work pattern in depth, and to discuss how best it might be accommodated. It also provides an opportunity to consider other alternative working patterns should there be problems in accommodating the work pattern outlined in the employee's application. The employee can, if they want, bring with them a worker employed by the same employer as a companion.

Within **14 days** after the date of the meeting the employer must write to the employee to either agree to a new work pattern and a start date; or to provide clear business grounds as to why the application cannot be accepted and the reason why the grounds apply in the circumstances and set out the appeal procedure. In the majority of cases this will be the end of the matter.

All time periods can be extended where both the employer and the employee agree. Any extensions must be recorded in writing by the employer and copied to the employee.

Can an employee appeal against the decision?

Yes. The procedure provides an employee with the right to appeal against their employer's decision within 14 days of being notified of it. The appeal process is designed to be in keeping with the overall aim of the right of encouraging both employer and employee to reach a satisfactory outcome at the workplace.

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Addendum - Ergonomics

Employers shall be obliged to perform an analysis of workstations in order to evaluate the safety and health conditions to which they give rise for their workers, particularly as regards possible risks to eyesight, physical problems and problems of mental stress.

Directive 90/270/EEC - display screen equipment

of 29 May 1990

The employer must plan the worker's activities in such a way that daily work on a display screen is periodically interrupted by breaks or changes of activity reducing the workload at the display screen.

DTI guide

Employers are required to do a suitable and sufficient risk assessment of all the work activities carried out by their workers under the Management of Health and Safety at Work Regulations 1992. This includes those who work from home or elsewhere. In the case of teleworkers, it is good practice for the teleworkers themselves to carry out a self-assessment of the risks from work activities carried out in the home.

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